



U.S. Navy

U.S. SAILORS prepare to load an F/A-18F Super Hornet on the Abraham Lincoln aircraft carrier Saturday.

Lawmakers question basis for war

According to President Trump, the United States attacked Iran because the Islamic Republic posed “imminent threats” to the U.S. and its allies, including through its use of terrorist proxies and continued pursuit of nuclear weapons.

“Its menacing activities directly endanger the United States, our troops, our bases overseas and our allies throughout the world,” he said in a recorded statement Saturday.

According to leading Democrats in Congress, Trump’s justification is questionable, especially given his claims of having “completely obliterated” Iran’s nuclear capabilities in separate U.S. bombings last June.

“Everything I have heard from the administration before and after these strikes

Democrats cast doubt on ‘imminent threat’ claim as some MAGA voices denounce attack

By Kevin Rector



DANIEL TOROK White House

PRESIDENT Trump with Chief of Staff Susie Wiles as Marco Rubio listens at Mar-a-Lago on Saturday.

on Iran confirms this is a war of choice with no strategic endgame,” said Rep. Jim Himes (D-Conn.), ranking Democrat on the House Intelligence Committee and part of a small group of congressional leaders — the Gang of Eight — who were briefed on the operation by Secretary of State Marco Rubio.

That divide is bound to remain an issue politically heading into this year’s midterm elections, and could be a liability for Republicans — especially considering that some in the “America first” wing of the MAGA base were raising their own objections, citing Trump’s 2024 campaign pledges to extricate the U.S. from foreign wars, not start new ones.

The debate echoed a sim-

[See **Lawmakers**, A5]

At least 3 U.S. troops killed in Iran conflict

Trump warns more American deaths are likely as Mideast violence spreads.

By GRACE TOOHEY AND GAVIN J. QUINTON

At least three U.S. service members are among the hundreds confirmed dead in a widening war across the Middle East, set off by a string of U.S. and Israeli attacks on Iran over the weekend that killed Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

Pledging to continue the “combat operations ... in full force,” President Trump on Sunday warned that more American troops may die in the escalating conflict.

“Sadly there will likely be more before it ends,” Trump said in an update about 36 hours after the first attacks. He offered condolences to the families of the three “true American patriots” who he said made the ultimate sacrifice for the nation, but said there will “likely be more. But we’ll do everything possible where that won’t be the case.”

Pentagon officials did not share circumstances about the deaths, including where the service members died. The news came as Iran continued to intensify counter-

attacks across the region, including on American military bases.

U.S. military officials said at least five other service members were seriously wounded and several others experienced minor shrapnel injuries and concussions.

Iranian officials continued to pledge revenge for the attacks across their country and especially for the killing of Khamenei on Saturday.

“To the countries of the region: We are not seeking to attack you,” Ali Larijani, a top Iranian official, said on X. “But when the bases located in your country are used against us, and when the United States carries out operations in the region relying on these forces, then we will target those bases.”

Casualties across the region mounted Sunday, as the war’s second day brought increased violence, with dozens of civilian deaths confirmed in Iran, Israel, Pakistan and the United Arab Emirates.

An Iranian missile attack on Sunday hit a synagogue in central Israel, killing at least nine people, bringing the country’s death toll to 11 since the start of its joint assault with the U.S. against Iran, according to Israeli officials. At least 28 others were wounded in the retaliatory strike and 11 others were still missing.

[See **Iran**, A4]

‘Axis of Resistance’

A look at the Iran-backed proxy militant groups, which Trump assailed in ordering U.S. strike. **A6**

Joy and tears in Tehran

As some Iranians mourn the death of their supreme leader, others cheer and dance in the streets. **A6**

UC leader prefers to talk, not battle

James Milliken says avoiding lawsuits over Trump’s funding cuts is the ‘better course.’

By JAWEED KALEEM

BERKELEY — University of California President James B. Milliken, in his first extensive interview since taking the helm of the nation’s premier public higher education system, defended UC’s diplomatic approach to President Trump’s fusillade of actions against the institution — contrasting it with the more aggressive fight Harvard is waging with the government.

UC has not repeatedly sued the federal government or publicly criticized Trump, while Harvard battles the administration in and outside court amid billions in White House funding freezes.

“We could have said, ‘We’re going to sue tomorrow.’ We saw that movie with Harvard,” Milliken said of his first seven months on the job dominated by federal attacks. “Harvard is still in negotiations to settle the federal government’s actions, but they have had a series of devastating enforcement actions taken. ... Given our responsibility to the university and to the state of California, the better course for us was to engage.”

Yet days after the interview, the U.S. Department of Justice leveled another strike against UC in a lawsuit alleging UCLA “routinely ignored” and “failed to report” employee complaints of antisemitism since 2023.

[See **Milliken**, A12]

COLUMN ONE

Bloodstains in a kingpin’s hideaway

A look in the Mexican compound where ‘El Mencho’ was killed

By KEEGAN HAMILTON
REPORTING FROM TAPALPA, MEXICO

The most wanted man in Mexico was hiding out next to a country club.

When Mexican special forces soldiers attacked the hideout of Nemesio Rubén Oseguera Cervantes — the cartel boss known as “El Mencho” — they descended on his luxurious compound in the mountains outside Guadalajara.

A cluster of upscale cabins situated on a steep hillside dotted with pine trees, the location offered seclusion and ensured that Oseguera’s security detail would be able to see any approaching visitors from miles away.

The only way in is a long, narrow, bumpy road. To maintain the ele-

[See **El Mencho**, A7]



FELIX MARQUEZ For The Times

LUXURY cabins in Tapalpa, Jalisco, where Mexican forces killed the cartel boss Nemesio Rubén Oseguera Cervantes, or “El Mencho.”

When deportation derails prosecution

Some immigrants facing removal escape punishment for drug, theft or other charges.

By BRITTNY MEJIA

Guillermo Zambrano faced at least 10 years in federal prison if convicted of working with Sinaloa cartel associates — but then ICE sought to deport him last

June. Now he faces none.

Zambrano, a Venezuelan citizen in the midst of political asylum proceedings in the U.S., pleaded not guilty to charges of helping conceal drug-trafficking proceeds. For 17 months, he remained free on a \$60,000 bond with an ankle monitor while awaiting trial in the Central District of California.

But amid President Trump’s immigration crack-down last summer, Immigration and Customs En-

forcement officers came to Zambrano’s home, removed his ankle monitor and took him into custody. The move surprised everyone, including prosecutors. If convicted, Zambrano would have faced deportation after serving a prison sentence.

When ICE didn’t release Zambrano from custody last month, U.S. District Judge Dolly M. Gee dismissed the criminal indictment with prejudice, barring the government from refiling the

same charges. Gee cited “an ongoing violation of Zambrano’s right to pretrial release.”

The dismissal underscores how the administration’s aggressive deportation push has begun to collide with federal prosecutions and exposes a clash of priorities between the Department of Homeland Security and the Department of Justice. In recent months, immigration authorities

[See **Conflict**, A9]

Gunman’s shirt had Iranian flag

An early morning mass shooting at a bar in Austin, Texas, killed two people and left 14 others wounded. **NATION**, **A8**

A gender divide in social media trial

Landmark case seeking to hold platforms liable for alleged harm to children reveals a crucial split. **CALIFORNIA**, **B1**

Big weekend for Oscar hopefuls

“One Battle After Another” wins producers’ prize. (For SAG, see latimes.com/awards.) **ENTERTAINMENT**, **E1**

Weather

Not as warm.
L.A. Basin: 71/53. **B5**



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